Stirred to the core, I genuinely felt I was witnessing not a speech but a universal truth. His words spoke to the best in us. I may be naive, but I feel that all of us just want to live with integrity and fight for equality, fraternity and dignity for all. I had inherited these core values along the way from my grandfather—a thorough Congressman unto death, who had recounted countless tales of prabhat pheris and padyatras that he had participated in or heard about. And suddenly, here was a man offering an opportunity to recreate the courage, sacrifice and idealism of our forefathers.

While I still wondered about where and how I would put my aahuti (offering) in this historical havan (sacred fire) for mankind, I quietly registered myself on the official website for the Bharat Jodo Yatra. I had not the remotest idea what fate was brewing for me. And when I was asked to join the Yatra as a media coordinator, tasked with organizing press conferences, preparing notes that informed press notes and liaising with the media in different states, I jumped with exhilaration at this once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. Once the initial excitement had passed, I became a bit introspective. Yes, it was a huge privilege, but it was also an enormous task for a novice. I was a media panellist (but only an amateur) and a third-generation ‘Congressi’. But did this equip me enough to work on such a huge scale?

With great difficulty, I braced myself for the assignment and set out for the journey. Only one thing was certain to me (that I kept repeating to myself like a mantra)—that no matter what, I would ‘walk’ the task like never before, dutifully, zealously, curiously, consistently. This was my chance to discover the politics that I’ve known all my life but never experienced. This strong sense of commitment was not just to the Yatra but also to myself.

As we began our preparations, we could not help but notice the speculations around. The Yatra was soliciting curiosities galore and everyone’s enthusiasm was at their peak. After I, along with most others, had been briefed by the leaders of the Congress party’s media and publicity department, I established contact with others whom I would be sailing this ship with. Innumerable WhatsApp groups, Zoom meetings and long